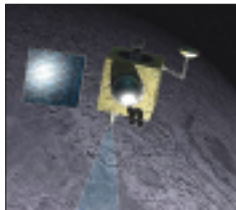
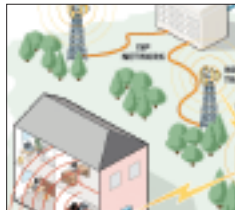




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Main Story

Cleaning up the Vista

Ahmed Shaikh

We hate Microsoft for Windows Vista. Here was an OS we were truly excited for — DirectX 10 accelerated, vector graphics, an all-new communications layer, tweaks and rewrites at the kernel level, a new interface — it promised all the right things. And delivered little more than a badly-implemented security feature (UAC), an Orb where the Start button used to be, a ridiculous enhancement to [Alt] + [Tab] (seriously, who uses the Flip 3D?), and a Sidebar / Gadgets feature copied from sundry, and free, programs.

If you think we're being a little too hard on Microsoft, then right you are. After all, we need to spend almost an entire month's pay to purchase Windows Vista Ultimate Edition, and all we got for it was a half-decent game (*Tinker*), a crash-happy feature (DreamScene, a desktop background utility that was promptly ripped and released for Windows XP), and a bunch of stuff we don't care about (BitLocker, language packs, sound schemes, poker)... So yeah, it's personal.

Apparently, we're not the only ones with either disdain or apathy for Windows Vista — market surveys by various organisations show that Vista's OS market share hovers around 20 per cent, as of December 2008... It's a broken OS.

Fixing Vista

So Vista's a wash. The consumers know it, and Microsoft knows it (hence the Mojave experi-

A first-hand experience with Windows 7 Beta

ment and the "I am a PC" advertisements). And so we have Windows 7. Microsoft's approach to this 'new' OS is clearly communicated through the Windows 7 web site — "Over the past few years, you've asked us to make some changes to Windows...", it says, "We listened closely." Windows 7, is thus, all about fixing Vista.

What are these fixes? Most of the changes can be summed up in one word — *streamlined*. Windows 7 Beta

is a more refined and streamlined version of Vista. The annoying UAC is significantly less irritating now, to the point of actually being useful and not constant mothering by an overbearing OS. Windows itself makes better use of some of the structural changes introduced in Vista — Aero is much more than a shiny coat, Search is much improved, network management is a lot simpler, bootup is faster, Windows itself feels a lot more snappier, copying of data across media is no longer a chore, and moreover Windows 7 Beta introduces some welcome, and dare we say, great changes to the Windows way of getting things done.

While adding features, Windows 7 also throws away some applications otherwise bundled. Whether this is a fallout of their legal escapades, we don't know, but Messenger, Mail, and Gallery are now moved out of the Windows installation and packaged separated under the Windows Live banner. Hopefully, this will allow for greater innovation from the Live team.

